



Many animals need a place for shelter. There are various reasons why they do this: somewhere to *sleep, raise their young*, escape from predators, or simply *take refuge* from the weather. Animals take advantage of natural holes in trees or rocks, but some go to great lengths to create the perfect home.

*Hey there,
how are you
doing with that
extension?*

HORNBILL

High-rise hangout

A hole high in a tree trunk is an excellent place to raise a family, which makes it an ideal home for birds and many tree-climbing animals. That doesn't always make it safe—snakes will climb trees in search of prey. Tree holes happen naturally when part of the trunk decays, or they are excavated by birds like the woodpecker. Holes at the base of the tree are used as dens by bears for shelter and to give birth to cubs. Hollow logs also provide homes for small animals and a wide variety of insect species.

Secluded property

Caves are ideal places for animals to escape the weather. Bears occupy them during the winter and tigers use them to shelter from the heat. Fish slip into underwater caves and crevices in rocks to escape predators or to lie in wait for prey to pass by. Some marine animals use caves to protect their eggs or young. Bats use the darkness of caves to hide from daylight, only coming out at night to feed.

UNUSUAL HOMES



Honduran white bats build a tent out of a large leaf by biting through the leaf ribs and folding it over themselves.



Female polar bears make dens in the ice during the Arctic winter to give birth and raise their cubs in safety.



Trap-door spiders dig a hole, which they seal with a lid. At night they lift the lid, grab a passing insect, and slam it shut again.



*I thought you
said that cave
was empty?*

leaves and branches every night to sleep in.